2.1 Free African Americans Gain a Voice

Think of a time when you've stepped up to be a leader or you've done something hard and unfamiliar. You probably felt both nervous and proud. That may well have been how many African Americans felt as they took part in the political process for the first time.

MAIN IDEA During Radical Reconstruction, African Americans participated in government, established churches of their own, and tried to reestablish kinship structures.

TAKING PUBLIC OFFICE

After Congress passed the Reconstruction Acts, African Americans attained political freedom and wanted to exercise their new political power. As a result, many African-American citizens from the North, newly organized as Republicans, moved to the South hoping to fill appointed or elected government positions. African Americans from the South, some of whom had been free before the war, also sought leadership roles. These men became the backbone of the Republican Party in southern districts with large African-American populations.

African Americans everywhere wanted the ability to make their own choices. Many wanted to be involved in their states' readmission into the Union. Throughout the South, local African-American leaders, ministers, and Republicans encouraged newly freed men to register and vote. Their efforts helped Republican delegates dominate state constitutional conventions in every state except Georgia. African Americans also participated as delegates in all state conventions. Across the South, in fact, African Americans accounted for some 265 delegates out of a total of slightly more than 1,000. Between 1865 and 1877, African Americans influenced the direction of southern politics and elected 22 members of Congress. Republican-dominated legislatures established the first publicly financed education systems in the South, provided debt relief to the poor, and expanded women's rights.

About 600 African Americans also participated directly in the new state legislatures. Although no African Americans were elected governor, several served as lieutenant governors, secretaries of state, judges, or treasurers. **Pinckney Pinchback**, the lieutenant governor of Louisiana, became the acting governor when the state charged his boss with corruption.

African Americans became leaders at the national level when **Hiram Rhodes Revels** and **Blanche K. Bruce** served in the U.S. Senate. Revels, who was born a free man, served in Mississippi's state senate. He went on to fill a U.S. Senate seat left vacant when Mississippi seceded from the Union. He was the first African American to serve in the U.S. Senate. Bruce, who had been born into slavery, also represented Mississippi. He was the second African American to serve in the U.S. Senate and the first to be elected to a full term. In addition, 14 African Americans served in the U.S. House of Representatives during the Reconstruction era.

CHURCH AND FAMILY

Hiram Revels was already familiar in the African-American community in Mississippi through his work as a minister in the African Methodist Episcopal Church. Churches had long been at the center of African-American life. Because ministers were often the most educated members of the community, they became natural leaders—not only in religious matters but also in politics.

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.



First African Americans in U.S. Congress

The seven men in this print from 1872 are the first African Americans to serve in the U.S. Congress. Together, the seven represented five southern states. From left to right, the men are Senator Hiram Rhodes Revels of Mississippi (who filled the Senate seat that Jefferson Davis had held), Congressman Benjamin S. Turner of Alabama, Congressman Robert C. De Large of South Carolina, Congressman Josiah T. Walls of Florida, Congressman Jefferson F. Long of Georgia, Congressman Joseph Rainey of South Carolina, and Congressman Robert B. Elliot of South Carolina.

Following the Civil War, African Americans quickly established their own churches. The new churches were often Baptist because that denomination allowed each congregation to start a church independently and organize the services the way it wanted. By 1890, about 1.3 million African Americans were members of Baptist churches, mostly in the South. Churches were central to the African-American quest for **social justice**, or fair distribution of opportunities and privileges, including racial equality and rights. In addition to providing a place of worship, African-American churches often served as gathering places for social and political events and housed schools.

Like churches, family life had always been important to African Americans. But as you know, slavery had often split up families when members were sold to different owners. During Reconstruction, many African Americans tried to locate and reunite with their families. They were helped in this effort by the Freedmen's Bureau. In some cases, the bureau succeeded, particularly when the separated members of a family had gone to nearby plantations. Unfortunately, in other cases, family members had been sent far away. Some African Americans traveled hundreds of miles searching for their loved ones—often in vain.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did African-American political participation help strengthen the Republican Party in the South?
2. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why do you think it was important for African Americans to establish their own churches?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** Why were African Americans strongly motivated to influence and become leaders in government?

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.